

Greenway Trail receives grant

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LISBON - Sean Logan was in town Friday with a check for \$120,355 to help efforts to complete the Little Beaver Creek Greenway Trail.

Logan, a former Columbiana County commissioner and state legislator, is director of the Ohio Department of Natural Resources for Gov. Ted Strickland. He and state Rep. Linda Bolon announced the awarding of the Clean Ohio Trails fund grant to the county Park District for the trail during a ceremony at the historic train station.

The 10-mile bicycle-walking trail currently runs from Lisbon to Leetonia. The grant money will be used to help cover the cost of extending the trail from East High Street in Leetonia to Bertolette Alley in Washingtonville, a distance of about 1.5 miles.

This will bring the trail within proximity of the Mahoning County line, where the hope is it will eventually link up with a trail the Mahoning County Metroparks is planning to extend south to Columbiana County.

Park Board President Dottie Betz said about half of the \$120,355 will be used to cover the engineering costs, with the rest going to development of the trail, which will continue to follow the old rail bed of the former Erie & Lackawanna Railway. The total project cost is \$460,000, with federal funding to cover the majority of the expense.

Betz said the park district must still come up with \$40,000 to cover the local match to qualify for the funding, and she is confident they will find the money.

The money for the grant program comes from a statewide bond issue passed by voters in 2000. The park district has a pending application for a \$26,430 grant through the Clean Ohio Conservation Fund, which also is funded by the bond issue. This grant would help purchase land on Bertolette Alley in Washingtonville and serve as the northern terminus for the trail.

If everything works out, the trail extension could become a reality by 2012. This is all part of a larger effort to create a continuous trail that would run from Lake Erie to the Ohio River by linking trails in Columbiana, Mahoning, Trumbull and Ashtabula counties.